

Dinosaur fossils

Dinosaur fossils occur in layers of rock that formed millions of years ago. Scientists excavate (dig up) the fossils in places where the movement of Earth's tectonic plates has forced these layers to the surface.

Barosaurus 3

Ornithomimus 6

Tyrannosaurus 7

Coelophysis 1

Eoraptor 2

ZHUCHENG, OR DINOSAUR CITY, IN CHINA HAS YIELDED MORE THAN 7,600 FOSSILS

KEY

The dinosaur age spanned three geological periods. Fossil sites are colored according to period (mya = million years ago).

- Triassic (251–200 mya)
- Jurassic (200–145 mya)
- Cretaceous (145–65 mya)

Major fossil sites

Triassic

- 1 **Ghost Ranch, US**
Thousands of *Coelophysis* found here in 1947. They died when caught in a flash flood about 215 mya.
- 2 **Valle de la Luna, Argentina**
Eoraptor—perhaps the first true dinosaur, from about 230 mya—was discovered here in 1993.

Jurassic

- 3 **Dinosaur National Monument, US**
Famed for long-necked sauropod dinosaurs, such as *Barosaurus*.
- 4 **Solnhofen, Germany**
Archaeopteryx, an ancestor of modern birds, was discovered here in 1861.

Cretaceous

- 5 **Liaoning, China**
Many birdlike dinosaur fossils have been unearthed here, including the turkey-sized *Caudipteryx*.